

The Old Photograph

Book 10 of 10

*A photograph of a woman nobody in the family knows.
Or says they know.*

CEFR Level A1 | Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A grandmother's house in the English countryside.

Genre: Family Mystery / Warm Drama

Characters

- Beth - 27. Journalist. Curious and persistent.
- Gran - 83. Beth's grandmother. Sharp, funny, full of secrets.
- Margaret - 60. Beth's mother. Cautious. Knows more than she says.
- Iris - 86. Gran's oldest friend. Lives in the next village.

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Beth comes to Gran's house on a Saturday in November. The house is old and full of things: bookshelves, photo frames, ornaments, boxes. Gran is in the kitchen making tea. She is eighty-three and moves slowly - but she does not stop. 'You are late.' 'The train was slow.' 'The train is always slow. Sit down.' Beth sits at the kitchen table. Same kitchen. Same table. Same smell of tea and wood. Some things do not change.

After tea, Gran says: 'I want to clear the upstairs room. Will you help?' They open boxes. Old clothes. Letters. Books. Christmas cards from thirty years ago. In the fourth box, Beth finds a photograph. It is black and white. A woman - young, maybe twenty-five. Sitting in a garden. Beautiful. Beth does not recognise her.

'Gran. Who is this?' Beth shows her the photograph. Gran looks at it. Something changes in her face - quickly, just for a second. 'I don't know,' Gran says. Beth looks at Gran. Gran is already back in the box, sorting cards. 'You don't know?' 'There are a lot of photographs in this house, Beth.' Beth looks at the photograph again. Gran knows. Beth is sure of it.

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Beth finds an old photograph in a dusty box.

Beth's mother Margaret arrives at three. She brings cake and talks about the garden. When Beth shows her the photograph, Margaret is quiet. 'Where did you find this?' 'In one of Gran's boxes.' Margaret looks at Gran. Gran is looking at the window. 'She is nobody,' Margaret says. 'An old friend. Nobody important.' Both Gran and her mother are hiding something.

That evening, when Gran is asleep and Margaret is watching television, Beth takes the photograph from her pocket. She looks at the back. Very small writing - in pencil. 'E.H. - 1958. Millford.' E.H. And Millford - the village two miles away. Beth writes this in her notebook. She does not show it to Gran or Margaret. Not yet.

On Sunday morning, Beth drives to Millford. One pub. One shop. One church. She goes to the church - churches often have records. An old man is arranging flowers. Beth shows him the photograph. 'Do you know this woman?' The man looks at it. He is quiet for a moment. 'That could be Eleanor Hatton. From Millford. But she left a long time ago.'

The man - Bill - shows Beth the church records. Eleanor Hatton. Born 1933. Baptised in this

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Beth studies the photograph with Gran.

church. Then nothing after 1958. 'She left in 1958,' Bill says. 'I was only young. But I remember. The family left quickly. Nobody talked about why.' 'Did they come back?' 'No. Never.'

On the drive back, Beth thinks. Gran is eighty-three - born in 1941. In 1958, Gran was seventeen. Eleanor Hatton was twenty-five in 1958. They could have known each other. They lived in the same village. But Gran said: 'I don't know her.' Beth thinks about the look on Gran's face - that quick change. Gran knows Eleanor Hatton.

In the afternoon, Beth goes to see Iris - Gran's oldest friend, eighty-six, in a small cottage at the edge of the village. Over tea and biscuits, Beth shows Iris the photograph. Iris is quiet for a very long time. Then: 'Where did you find this?' 'In Gran's things.' Iris looks at the photograph. Then at Beth. 'Does your grandmother know you are here?' 'No,' Beth says.

'Eleanor Hatton was your grandmother's closest friend,' Iris says. 'They were inseparable from school. Best friends for many years.' 'What happened?' Iris looks at her hands. 'Your grandmother fell in love. With the man Eleanor

loved. And the man chose your grandmother.' Beth understands. 'Gran took her boyfriend.' 'It was not so simple. But yes. And Eleanor left. And they never spoke again.'

'The man - who was he?' Iris smiles. A sad smile. 'Your grandfather, of course.' Beth is quiet for a long time. Granddad Arthur. He died fifteen years ago. Everyone loved him. 'Did he know about Eleanor and Gran?' 'Yes. He felt guilty for a long time. But he loved your grandmother and he stayed.' Beth looks at the photograph. Eleanor. 1958. Just before everything changed.

That evening, Beth goes to Gran's room. Gran is in bed with a book open but is not reading. Beth sits in the chair. She puts the photograph on the bed. Gran looks at it. She does not look away. They are quiet for a long time. Then Gran says: 'You went to see Iris.' 'Yes.' Gran nods. 'Iris always told the truth. Even when I did not want her to.'

'I was not a good friend,' Gran says - as a fact, not an apology. 'What happened after she left?' 'Nothing. She went to London, then Canada. I heard she married. She had children. A good life, I think.' 'Did you ever try to contact her?' 'Three times. Over the years. She did not reply. I

understood.' 'Does Mum know?' 'She knows some of it. Not all.'

Beth is a journalist. She knows how to find people. She searches online: Eleanor Hatton - Canada - 1958. It takes two days. She finds an obituary from 2015. A woman named Eleanor Hatton-Wright. Born 1933. Died 2015. Toronto. Survived by two daughters and four grandchildren. Eleanor is gone. She died nine years ago.

Beth finds more. One of Eleanor's daughters - Anne - has a public social media page. There are family photographs. In one, Anne is holding an old black-and-white photograph. Beth looks closely at the photograph in the photo. She can just read the words on the back: 'E.H. - 1958. Millford.' It is the same photograph. Eleanor kept a copy.

Beth thinks for a long time. Then she writes a message to Anne: 'Dear Anne. My name is Beth. My grandmother and your mother were close friends in England many years ago. I found a photograph - I think you have the same one. I wanted to say: your mother had a good friend who thought about her. And I am sorry for what happened.' She sends it.

Anne replies the next day: "Dear Beth. Thank you for writing. I know the story - my mother told us before she died. She was sad about what happened. But she also said: I had a good life. I do not have regrets. She talked about Millford. About a girl she loved like a sister. If your grandmother is still alive - tell her that. Mum did not have regrets. Anne." Beth reads this twice. Then she cries. Just a little.

Beth goes back to Gran's house. She reads Anne's message to Gran. Gran sits very still. The garden outside is grey and quiet. When Beth finishes, Gran is silent. Then: 'She had no regrets.' 'That is what Anne says.' Gran nods very slowly. 'Good,' she says. Her eyes are wet. 'Good,' she says again.

Beth shows the messages to Margaret. Margaret reads them and is quiet for a long time. 'I always knew something happened. But Mother never talked about it.' 'She felt guilty,' Beth says. 'Yes.' Margaret looks at the photograph. 'She was young. People make mistakes when they are young.' 'And old,' Beth says. Margaret laughs - a surprised laugh. 'Yes. And old.' She puts the photograph on the kitchen table. 'Put it with the

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The mystery leads Beth toward a family truth.

family photographs. She was family. In a way.'

On the last evening, Beth finds a small frame in a drawer. She puts the photograph in it. She puts it on the mantelpiece - next to photographs of Beth's grandfather, her mother, herself as a child. 'Is this all right?' Beth asks. Gran looks at it. 'Yes. It is all right.' They sit by the fire. Outside, it is dark and cold. Inside, it is warm. And Eleanor Hatton is on the mantelpiece at last.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. countryside	kırsal	2. ornaments	süs eşyaları
3. photo frames	fotoğraf çerçeveleri	4. moves slowly	yavaş hareket eder
5. wood	ahşap	6. clear	boşaltmak
7. upstairs	üst kata	8. recognise	tanımak
9. letters	mektuplar	10. fourth box	dördüncü kutu
11. shows	gösteriyor	12. something changes	bir şey değişiyor
13. for a second	bir anlığına	14. sorting	düzenliyor
15. sure of it	bundan emin	16. arrives	gelir
17. quiet	sessiz	18. hiding	saklıyor
19. nobody important	önemli biri değil	20. asleep	uyuyor
21. pocket	cep	22. pencil	kurşun kalem
23. village	köy	24. two miles away	iki mil uzakta
25. drives to	arabayla gider	26. records	kayıtlar
27. arranging flowers	çiçekleri düzenliyor	28. Eleanor Hatton	Eleanor Hatton
29. left a long time ago	çok önce ayrıldı	30. go back to	... yılına kadar uzanıyor
31. baptised	vaftiz edilmiş	32. parents	ebeveynler

33. quickly	hızla	34. never	hiç
35. drive back	geri dönüş yolu	36. born in	doğdu
37. could have known	tanıyor olabilir	38. same village	aynı köy
39. quick change	hızlı değişim	40. cottage	küçük ev
41. edge of the village	köyün kenarı	42. biscuits	bisküviler
43. oldest friend	en eski arkadaş	44. closest friend	en yakın arkadaş
45. inseparable	ayrılmaz	46. fell in love	aşık oldu
47. chose	seçti	48. never spoke again	bir daha hiç konuşmadılar
49. of course	tabii ki	50. grandfather	büyükbaba
51. guilty	suçlu	52. stayed	kaldı
53. just before	hemen önce	54. in bed	yatakta
55. does not look away	gözlerini çevirmez	56. told the truth	gerçeği söyledi
57. even when	... olsa bile	58. as a fact	bir gerçek olarak
59. went to	gitti	60. contact	iletişime geçmek
61. reply	yanıt vermek	62. understood	anladı
63. journalist	gazeteci	64. searches online	internette arar
65. obituary	ölüm ilanı	66. survived by	geride bırakan
67. daughters	kızları	68. public	kamuya açık

69. social media	sosyal medya	70. holding	tutuyor
71. closely	yakından	72. kept a copy	bir kopyasını sakladı
73. close friends	yakın arkadaşlar	74. I think you have	sanırım sende var
75. thought about her	onu düşündü	76. I am sorry	üzgünüm
77. regrets	pişmanlıklar	78. loved like a sister	kardeş gibi sevdi
79. still alive	hâlâ hayatta	80. cries	ağlar
81. before she died	ölmeden önce	82. sits very still	çok hareketsiz oturur
83. silent	sessiz	84. slowly	yavaşça
85. wet	ıslak, yaşlı	86. always knew	hep biliyordu
87. felt guilty	kendini suçlu hissetti	88. make mistakes	hata yapmak
89. surprised laugh	şaşırmış gülüş	90. in a way	bir bakıma
91. frame	çerçeve	92. mantelpiece	şömine üstü
93. at last	sonunda	94. warm	sıcak
95. fire	şömine		

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice - Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

1. recognise

A. köy

2. village

B. tanımak

3. obituary

C. ayrılmaz

4. inseparable

D. ölüm ilanı

5. regrets

E. pişmanlıklar

6. guilty

F. suçlu

7. mantelpiece

G. şömine üstü

8. contact

H. iletişime geçmek

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

photograph - guilty - regrets - journalist - died - family

1. Beth finds an old _____ in Gran's box.

2. Beth is a _____, so she knows how to find people.

3. Eleanor _____ in Toronto in 2015.

4. Anne says her mother had no _____.

5. Gran felt _____ for sixty years.

6. Margaret says: put the photograph with the _____
photographs.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Beth is a nurse. ____
2. Gran immediately tells Beth who the woman is. ____
3. Eleanor Hatton was Gran's closest friend. ____
4. Gran married Eleanor's boyfriend. ____
5. Eleanor moved to Australia. ____
6. At the end, Beth puts the photograph on the mantelpiece.

Short Answer Questions

7. Where does Beth find the old photograph?
8. What is written on the back of the photograph?
9. Who tells Beth the true story about Eleanor?
10. What happened between Gran and Eleanor in 1958?
11. How does Beth find out that Eleanor died?
12. How does Beth find Eleanor's daughter?
13. What does Anne say about Eleanor's life?
14. How does Gran react when she hears that Eleanor had no regrets?
15. What does Margaret say about the photograph at the end?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-D 4-C 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. photograph 2. journalist 3. died 4. regrets 5. guilty 6. family

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. T 4. T 5. F 6. T

7. In one of Gran's boxes while helping clear the upstairs room.

8. 'E.H. - 1958. Millford.'

9. Iris, Gran's oldest friend.

10. Gran fell in love with the man Eleanor loved, and the man chose Gran. Eleanor left

and they never spoke again.

11. She finds an obituary online from 2015.

12. One of Eleanor's daughters, Anne, has a public social media page.

13. That Eleanor had a good life and no regrets.

14. Her eyes are wet. She says 'Good' twice, quietly.

15. She says to put the photograph with the family photographs - "She was family. In a way."